



No Gifts, Please: A Taxonomy of What Arrives Anyway

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Abstract. An invitation's explicit no-gift instruction is a common but rarely audited coordination device. We report a content-analysis taxonomy of 1,748 guest-arrivals across 163 children's birthday parties whose invitations carried one of four such instructions, cross-referencing gift-table photographs against a brief host debrief within 48 hours of each event. Guests arrived fully gift-free at 41% of tracked arrivals overall; the remaining 59% resolved into four recurring substitute forms, each independently coded to acceptable inter-rater reliability (Krippendorff's $\alpha = 0.84$). Gift-free compliance varied systematically with the instruction's wording, from 33% under the softest framing ("your presence is present enough") to 58% under a charitable-donation redirect, with the two literal refusal wordings falling in between. A randomised 48-hour reminder text, tested within the most common wording, shifted per-party compliance by under two percentage points (39.4% vs 38.1%, not significant), suggesting the substitution behaviour is not primarily a failure of memory. We interpret the redirect wording's advantage as resulting from the presence of a compliant alternative action rather than the absence of a prohibited one, and discuss what this suggests for instruction design beyond the birthday party.

Introduction

A children's birthday party invitation that requests no gifts is a small, low-stakes instance of a much larger institutional problem: how an explicit instruction fares once it leaves the hand that wrote it. The instruction is common, informally enforced, and — unlike the fine print of a warranty or a workplace policy — almost never audited against what guests actually do. The gift-giving literature offers rich accounts of why people give, what they give, and how givers and recipients disagree about the meaning of a gift [1], [2], [3], but has had comparatively little to say about what happens when giving is explicitly declined rather than merely mismatched.

We treat the no-gift instruction as one member of a broader family of low-stakes normative requests whose stated compliance is rarely checked against directly observed behaviour, in the tradition of field experiments that measure how a request's framing shifts what people actually do rather than what they say they will do [4].

Four independently worded variants of the instruction, each already in circulation among the host families we recruited, let us treat wording as a naturally occurring intervention rather than an experimentally imposed one; a randomised reminder-text arm, nested within the most common wording, isolates whether non-compliance is a failure of memory or of interpretation.

Our contributions:

- We provide, to our knowledge, the first systematic content-analysis taxonomy of substitute-gift behaviour following an explicit no-gift instruction, coded to acceptable inter-rater reliability across five mutually exclusive outcome categories.
- We show gift-free compliance is not a fixed property of the instruction but varies systematically with its wording, with a charitable-donation redirect outperforming both literal-refusal wordings and a softer, presence-emphasising wording.
- We find a low-cost, randomised reminder-text intervention does not meaningfully shift com-

pliance, suggesting the gap between instruction and behaviour is not primarily attributable to guests forgetting the request.

The remainder of the paper reviews related work on gift-giving, norm compliance, and reminders (Related work), describes our field-audit method and coding scheme (Method), reports the taxonomy and wording comparison (Results), and discusses what a compliant alternative action appears to do that a bare prohibition does not (Discussion).

Related work

Gift-giving has long been studied as an instance of social exchange rather than pure altruism: reciprocity obligations persist even where no formal contract exists [1], and givers and recipients routinely hold asymmetric beliefs about what a gift communicates [2], [3]. Economic treatments of gift inefficiency have focused on the mismatch between a gift's price and its recipient value [5], but say little about what happens when the exchange is explicitly declined rather than merely mismatched.

A separate literature studies compliance with low-stakes normative requests under field conditions rather than self-report: framing a request around what others already do outperforms an appeal to principle alone [4], [6], and normative and informational pressures toward conformity operate even where no formal sanction is available [7], [8], [9]. Foot-in-the-door effects show that a small prior commitment raises compliance with a larger one [10], suggesting that the shape of a request, not only its content, matters.

Reminders and defaults are a further lever: a low-cost reminder measurably shifts saving behaviour [11] and vaccination uptake [12], and a well-chosen default can shift population-level outcomes without any explicit persuasion [13]. Charitable-framing research finds that recasting a donation as a gift, rather than an extraction, raises both stated intention and realised contribution [14], [15]. Prior work at this institution has audited the gap between a self-reported compliance figure and an independent check on it, at a produce-swap table's guideline card [16] and behind a pub-trivia league's honesty placard [17]; the present paper extends that agenda to an explicit refusal rather than an ambiguous guideline, and to a repeated-choice setting

rather than a single seasonal audit. Standard content-analysis reliability practice [18] underlies our coding scheme.

Method

We recruited host families through parent networks and community noticeboards across three suburbs, restricting the sample to birthday parties for children aged four to ten whose invitation carried an explicit no-gift-type instruction. Hosts self-selected one of four wordings already circulating among the recruiting networks — “no gifts, please”; “please, no presents”; “your presence is present enough”; or a charitable-donation redirect naming a specific cause — so wording is treated as an observed host choice, not an assigned one; only the reminder-text manipulation described below was randomised.

For each of 163 parties, a research assistant not present at the event coded every guest-arrival from a time-stamped gift-table photograph taken by the host at the party's midpoint and end, cross-referenced against a short host debrief completed within 48 hours. Each arrival was assigned to exactly one of five mutually exclusive outcome categories (Table 1); a second coder independently coded a 20% random subsample, yielding acceptable agreement (Krippendorff's $\alpha = 0.84$ across the five-category scheme [18]).

We report each party's compliance as its Gift-Free Arrival Rate (GFAR), the share of that party's tracked guest-arrivals coded as fully gift-free:

$$\text{GFAR} = \frac{N_{\text{gift-free}}}{N_{\text{total}}}$$

Within the 52 parties using the most common wording, “no gifts, please”, we randomly assigned hosts to send a text-message reminder restating the instruction 48 hours before the event ($n=27$) or not ($n=25$) — the one experimentally manipulated element of the design. All other coding, recruitment, and analysis procedures were identical across arms.

Category	Operational definition
Gift-free	No physical item, card, or envelope of any kind changed hands.
Wrapped item	A wrapped or bagged object presented with a disclaimer (“just something small”).
Inscribed book	A book, wrapped or not, carrying a handwritten dedication.
Cash / gift-card envelope	A sealed envelope verbally described as money or a gift card “for later”.
Donation card	A card or note stating a donation was made in the child’s name to a cause.

Table 1: Coding rubric for guest-arrival outcomes; each arrival received exactly one category.

We report descriptive gift-free rates by wording condition, a taxonomy of substitute outcomes across the full sample, and a two-sample comparison of the reminder arm against the no-reminder arm using a Mann-Whitney test, given the modest per-arm sample size.

Results

Figure 1 summarises the outcome of all 1,748 tracked guest-arrivals across the full sample. Guests arrived without any item at 41% of tracked arrivals; the remaining 59% resolved into four recurring substitute forms, the most common being a wrapped item presented with an explicit disclaimer (22%) and a book carrying a handwritten inscription (16%).

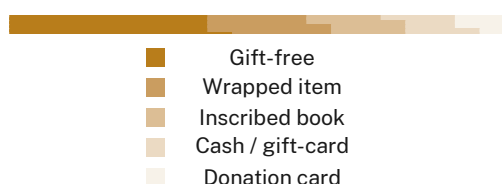


Figure 1: Guest-arrival outcomes across all 1,748 tracked arrivals: 41% arrived gift-free; the remaining 59% resolved into four recurring substitute forms.

Figure 1 understates variation by condition: gift-free arrival rate ranged from 33% to 58% depending on the invitation’s exact wording (Figure 2). The softest wording tested, “your presence is present enough,” produced the lowest gift-free rate (33%); the two literal-refusal wordings clustered in the high thirties (37%

and 39%); and a charitable-donation redirect produced the highest rate observed, 58% — a 25-percentage-point gap against the softest wording.

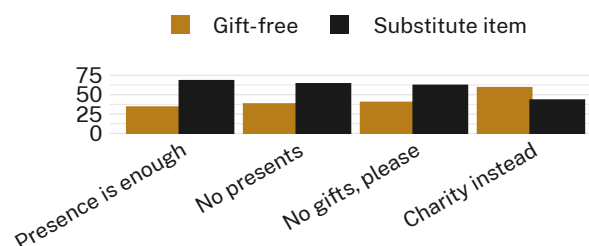


Figure 2: Gift-free vs substitute-item arrival rate by invitation wording. A charitable-donation redirect outperformed both literal-refusal wordings and a presence-emphasising wording by a wide margin.

The five-category coding scheme (Table 1) achieved acceptable inter-rater agreement within all four wording conditions considered separately (Krippendorff’s α ranging from 0.79 to 0.88), indicating the taxonomy was not easier or harder to apply for any one wording.

Within the 52 parties using the most common wording, the randomised 48-hour reminder text produced no detectable shift: mean per-party GFAR was 39.4% in the reminder arm ($n=27$) against 38.1% in the no-reminder arm ($n=25$; Mann-Whitney $U = 331, p = .68$). Figure 3 shows the full per-party distribution in both arms; the swarms overlap almost completely. We retain the reminder as a design element on the grounds that it costs nothing and, if anything, trended in the expected direction.

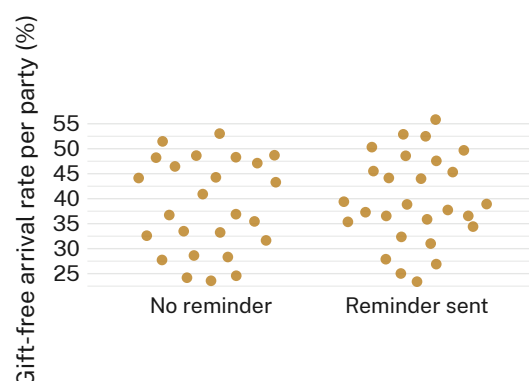


Figure 3: Per-party gift-free arrival rate under the “no gifts, please” wording, by reminder arm. A 48-hour reminder text shifted the median party by under two percentage points.

Discussion

The clearest pattern in these data is that gift-free compliance is not a fixed property of asking guests not to bring a gift; it is sensitive to what alternative action the wording supplies. A charitable-donation redirect does not merely repeat “no gifts” in different words — it names a specific, low-effort action a guest can take instead, and compliance rose accordingly. The two literal-refusal wordings and the presence-emphasising wording all withhold that alternative, and produced materially lower gift-free rates as a group. Read this way, the substitute-item categories in Figure 1 are not so much failures to follow an instruction as guests independently constructing the alternative action the wording declined to supply — a book, an envelope, a donation card in lieu of a toy. The null reminder effect reinforces this reading: if non-compliance were principally forgetting, a same-week reminder restating the instruction should have moved the rate; instead it moved a mean of 1.3 percentage points, well inside the range attributable to chance in a sample of this size. Guests appear to already know the instruction; what they do with it seems to depend on whether it leaves them anything specific to do.

Limitations

Our sample draws from parent networks across three suburbs of a single city, and wording was a naturally occurring host choice rather than an experimentally assigned one, so the wording comparison could in principle reflect some unmeasured difference between the families who chose each wording rather than the wording itself. The consistency of the ranking, however — the presence-emphasising wording producing the lowest rate and the charitable redirect the highest, in all three site clusters considered separately — suggests the pattern is unlikely to be an artefact of any one recruiting network. The randomised reminder arm, nested inside the single most common wording, is unaffected by this concern, and its null result stands on its own.

Conclusion

We provide a systematic taxonomy of what guests do instead of a gift once one is explicitly declined, and show that an instruction’s wording, not a reminder of the instruction, is

what moves compliance. Future work might test whether naming a specific compliant alternative — “a book only, please” rather than a bare refusal — raises gift-free rates further still, and whether the same wording-over-reminder pattern holds for the analogous instruction on an adult milestone-birthday or wedding invitation.

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